

## Unit -2

### Art of Happiness

#### Culture and Happiness

Different cultures experience happiness differently. Traditionally the West is considered materialistic, and happiness is said to come from achievement and acquisition. The East is said to be more people-oriented, where happiness is a result of deep personal interactions. Thus, poor people can be happier in the East than the West, because they are not so concerned with possession and more with society. Happiness Across Cultures considers happiness and quality of life in non-Western countries and cultures. Its coverage is diverse and spans the breadth of the non-Western world, revealing unique perspectives of happiness and life quality embedded in rich cultural traditions and histories.

Happiness is a universal goal, but the way people experience and express it is deeply influenced by their cultural background. Culture shapes how individuals define happiness, what they value, and the paths they pursue to achieve it. While some cultures view happiness as personal fulfilment and individual success, others see it as being closely tied to community, relationships, and harmony.

For example, **Western cultures** like the United States often emphasize **individualism** — where happiness is linked to personal achievements, freedom, and self-expression. In contrast, **Eastern cultures** such as those in Japan or China focus on **collectivism** — seeing happiness as maintaining social harmony, fulfilling family duties, and contributing to the community.

**happiness is not a "one-size-fits-all" concept** — it's shaped by personal values, societal expectations, and cultural traditions.

#### Meaning of Culture and Happiness

Culture and happiness are deeply interconnected concepts. Culture refers to the shared values, beliefs, customs, and behaviors of a group of people, shaping how individuals view the world — including their understanding of happiness. Happiness is a positive emotional state, often linked to life satisfaction, well-being, and a sense of purpose.

The relationship between culture and happiness lies in how different societies define and pursue happiness. While individualistic cultures (like those in the U.S. or Europe) often associate happiness with personal achievements, freedom, and self-expression, collectivist cultures (like those in Japan, China, or India) may tie happiness to family bonds, community harmony, and fulfilling social responsibilities.

In simple terms, culture influences:

- What makes people happy — whether it's success, relationships, or spiritual growth.

- How happiness is expressed — openly with excitement or subtly with contentment.
- The importance of happiness — as a personal goal or a collective achievement.

## Definition

Dalai Lama:

“Happiness is not something ready-made. It comes from your own actions.”

From a Buddhist perspective, happiness stems from inner peace, compassion, and mindfulness, emphasizing that true joy comes from within, not external circumstances.

The relationship between culture and happiness highlights that **happiness is not a universal concept** — it is deeply influenced by cultural backgrounds. While some cultures link happiness to personal achievements and independence, others tie it to community bonds and social harmony.

In simple terms:

- **Individualistic cultures** often define happiness through personal success and self-expression.
- **Collectivist cultures** associate happiness with fulfilling family duties, maintaining relationships, and contributing to society.

## Eastern and Western approaches to Happiness

In Indian traditions, the goal of life is to achieve success not only for personal happiness but also for the welfare of all creatures. No work can be more important or morally better than assisting those activities that contribute to the well-being of all. The pursuit of selfish desires is not a worthy goal of human actions. The idea is extended beyond ritual to other kinds of sacrifice or good actions. It has fundamentally the joy in heaven and the birth of a worthy son as the two ultimate desires of human beings in the ancient period. In China, there have been two major philosophical schools in ancient Confucianism and Mohism that emphasized the need for a harmonious society and care for the welfare of those in one's close vicinity. The legendary founder of Taoism said that to me, flowing in harmony is the way to behave; where the flow of life is, a person should feel at home. Eastern thoughts seem to aim at taking care of the peace and harmony available in the distant past, well before the historical divisions. This indicates a significant difference in the view of the development of the Eastern mind compared to the West. Eastern consciousness begins to arrive at the level of happiness that began with me and is beginning to shift towards compassion, moving from tears to cheer. In contrast to the ancient view of happiness in Western classical thought, where moral and intellectual virtue are considered more important than the acquisition of fulfilling desires, in the East, competencies such as balance, care, friendship, spirituality, and scientific understanding stand out

Eastern Approaches to Happiness:

- **Philosophical Roots:** Influenced by Buddhism, Taoism, Confucianism, and

Hinduism.

### Core Ideas

- **Inner Peace and Balance:** Happiness comes from within — detachment from desires, acceptance of suffering, and finding balance
- **Collectivism:** Prioritizing harmony in relationships and community well-being.
- **Mindfulness and Present Moment:** Living in the present moment, as seen in Buddhist teachings on mindfulness (*sati*).
- **Spiritual Growth:** Pursuing enlightenment or self-transcendence rather than material success.

### Key Concepts

- Eastern philosophy has been concerned with happiness in terms of cultivating holistic well-being.
- To begin this understanding of interconnection between all things, we need to cultivate in ourselves an enlightened form of love and compassion.
- We must instead strive to live our lives moment by moment in full awareness
- There are two philosophies in context to it: **love and compassion.**
- The most important product of enlightenment for both Hinduism and Buddhism is ethical living
- We must be conscious of the law of karma, for if we are not, we will experience dissatisfaction. In this respect, karma has come to be both the action we choose and the suffering that is the effect of life lived in unconsciousness
- Hindu and Buddhist philosophies also emphasize the principle of detachment as a key to happiness.
- In sum, in the East, happiness is not just about feeling good and peaceful. It is also about being connected to or having knowledge of, the interconnectedness of all things.
- Finally, spiritual reflection on the nature of reality is helpful and can lead to a deep, lasting state of satisfying happiness. In short, for Eastern philosophies, happiness is not seen as a state but rather as a process

## Western Approaches to Happiness

As happiness is one of the translated ideas that has existed almost as long as the history of thought, there are various theories about the nature of happiness, ways to attain it, criteria to measure it, types of happiness, and determinants of happiness. Two main philosophical traditions have struggled for more than 200 years on the locus of happiness. This section and the section following it will focus on two dominant traditions: the Western idea and the Eastern idea. In ancient Greece, happiness, considered related to ethics, was viewed in the context of virtues, and virtues were pursued in the process of achieving happiness. Plato predicted that the aim of human beings would be the realization of the essence of a person through a hierarchy of knowledge.

- **Philosophical Roots:** Influenced by ancient Greek philosophy (like Aristotle's *eudaimonia*), Enlightenment thinkers, and modern psychology.

Core Ideas:

- **Individualism:** Personal fulfillment and self-actualization are key, often tied to achievements and freedom of choice.
- **Pursuit of Pleasure and Meaning:** The balance between *hedonic* (pleasure-based) happiness and *eudaimonic* (meaning-based) happiness.
- **Positive Psychology:** Modern psychology emphasizes gratitude, optimism, and goal-setting for a sense of well-being.
- **Material and Social Success:** While evolving, there's still a focus on external markers of success like career, wealth, and status.
- **Key Concepts**

Happiness is a key philosophical and ethical concern for the Western world. Modern Western society, in particular, is constituted around values that closely relate to and endorse certain ideas of what it means to be happy and to have 'made something of ourselves.' Key concepts that have become familiar in the Western philosophy of happiness across history include: individuality or agency, rooted particularly in Hellenistic and Enlightenment thought; personal autonomy, closely related to individuality, largely influenced by Hellenistic and modern ideas of freedom; the quest for pleasure as energy and for the minimization of pain, dating from the ancient Greeks; the crucial role of reason in determining how the good-life happiness should be approached; and strong connections between happiness, the self-reflective, and the critical potential of a person. Many of the central philosophical concerns of Western life and society, therefore, are fastened to the values set up during life's philosophical beginnings and are closely connected to the dramas familiar to us at an unconscious level. For example, it has been claimed that our modern, liberal way of understanding a life worth living is traceable back to the ancient Hellenic world, filtered most importantly through the lens of Aristotle and his concept of *eudaimonia*. Central to this idea is that a life worth living concerns the personal development and acting out of an individual character through the commitment to some important personal values, and in some cases carried out in connection with others. Typically, such individuals resonate a sense of 'vigor' and 'activity.' This conception translates into 'the individualism' of the Western liberal tradition.

## **Hedonism**

**Hedonism** believes that **happiness comes from pleasure and enjoyment.**

### **Key Idea:**

*The more pleasure and less pain you have, the happier you are.*

### **Main Features:**

- Focuses on **immediate pleasure**
- Avoids pain and discomfort
- Includes physical and emotional pleasures
- Happiness is **subjective** (depends on personal feelings)

### **Examples:**

- Eating tasty food
- Shopping or buying luxury items
- Watching movies, partying, entertainment
- Money is important because it helps get pleasure

### **Limitation:**

- Pleasure is **temporary**
- May lead to emptiness if life lacks purpose

## **Eudaimonism (Eudonism)**

Eudaimonism believes that true happiness comes from living a meaningful and purposeful life.

### **Key Idea:**

Happiness is about being a good human being and fulfilling one's potential.

### **Main Features:**

- Focuses on inner growth and self-realization
- Values virtue, ethics, and personal development
- Happiness is long-term and deeper
- Not dependent only on pleasure or money

### **Examples:**

- Helping others
- Personal growth and learning
- Following moral values
- Achieving long-term goals
- Finding meaning in work or relationships

### **Advantage:**

- Leads to lasting satisfaction and inner peace

## Hedonism vs Eudaimonism (Quick Comparison)

| Basis                | Hedonism               | Eudaimonism         |
|----------------------|------------------------|---------------------|
| Meaning of happiness | Pleasure and enjoyment | Meaning and purpose |
| Time focus           | Short-term             | Long-term           |
| Role of money        | Very important         | Not central         |
| Nature of happiness  | Temporary              | Lasting             |
| Example              | Fun, luxury            | Growth, service     |

- **Hedonism** = *Feeling good*
- **Eudaimonism** = *Living well*

A balanced life often includes **both** pleasure (hedonism) and purpose (eudaimonism).

## Eastern and Western View Connection

### Western Approach to Happiness

- More aligned with **Hedonism**
- Focus on success, money, comfort, achievement
- Happiness seen as **personal pleasure and freedom**

### Eastern Approach to Happiness

- More aligned with **Eudaimonism**
- Focus on inner peace, duty (dharma), self-control
- Happiness seen as inner balance and purpose of life

## Can Money Buy Happiness? (Linking Concept)

- **Hedonism:**  
Yes, money can buy pleasure (luxury, comfort)  
But pleasure is temporary
- **Eudaimonism:**  
Money alone cannot buy meaning or inner peace  
Happiness comes from values, purpose, and relationships

# Relationship between Happiness and Money

## Introduction

Happiness and money occupy prominent places in both personal aspirations and academic inquiry. While **happiness** can be broadly defined as a sustained state of well-being—encompassing life satisfaction, frequent positive affect, and minimal negative feelings—**money** serves as the principal means by which individuals satisfy their material needs and pursue life goals. Understanding how these two concepts interact is vital for students of the Art of Happiness, because it illuminates why financial success alone may not guarantee lasting contentment and how non-material factors often play a decisive role.

## Defining the Constructs

- **Happiness:** A multidimensional construct that psychologist’s segment into (a) hedonic well-being (pleasure and avoidance of pain) and (b) eudaimonic well-being (meaning, purpose, and personal growth).
- **Money:** Not merely currency, but the broader concept of economic resources—including income, wealth, and access to goods and services—that enable individuals to meet basic needs, pursue opportunities, and manage uncertainties.

## Why Study the Relationship?

- **Policy Implications:** Governments use metrics like GDP per capita and happiness indices to guide economic and social policies.
- **Personal Well-Being:** Individuals often equate higher earnings with greater life satisfaction, yet research shows a **threshold effect** beyond which more income yields diminishing returns.
- **Cultural Significance:** Across societies, cultural norms shape whether wealth is seen as a primary route to happiness or simply as a tool among many.

## Theoretical Perspectives

| Theory / Model               | Key Idea                                                                                                                                |
|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Maslow’s Hierarchy of Needs  | Money helps satisfy physiological (food, shelter) and safety needs—prerequisites for higher-level happiness.                            |
| Easterlin Paradox (1974)     | Within a country, richer individuals report greater happiness; over time, average national happiness does not rise with average income. |
| Diminishing Marginal Utility | Each additional unit of income yields less incremental happiness once basic needs are met.                                              |
| Self-Determination Theory    | Happiness stems from autonomy, competence, and relatedness—money only indirectly supports these.                                        |
| PERMA Model (Seligman)       | Money can boost Positive emotion Engagement but not necessarily Meaning or Relationships.                                               |

### III Cultural and Contextual Factors

1. **Eastern cultures** - In many **Eastern cultures**—for example, in India, Japan, or China—the emphasis is often on community, family harmony, and spiritual balance. In these settings, people may place less value on individual wealth and more on fulfilling social roles, practicing gratitude, and maintaining close relationships. Even if someone earns a high income, they may feel happiest when they share resources with family, help neighbours, or take part in religious and cultural rituals that reinforce a sense of belonging.
2. **Western cultures** - By contrast, in many **Western cultures**, like the United States or much of Europe, there is a stronger focus on individual achievement and personal freedom. Here, having more money often translates directly into more choices—whether that’s the freedom to travel, switch careers, or buy luxury goods. Social comparison (“keeping up with the Joneses”) also tends to be more pronounced: people look at their peers’ lifestyles and measure their own success accordingly. This can drive consumption but also create stress if one’s income doesn’t keep pace with those around them.
3. **Social safety net** - Another key contextual factor is the **social safety net** provided by governments. In countries with robust public services—universal healthcare, subsidized education, and unemployment benefits—people feel less financial anxiety about medical bills or school fees. That peace of mind often boosts overall life satisfaction, even if individual incomes are modest. On the other hand, in places where such services are scarce or expensive, people clearly see the direct link between having enough savings or steady income and avoiding constant worry.

All these cultural and contextual layers remind us that while money provides the means to meet many needs, its true value for our happiness depends on **how** it is used, **who** we share our lives with, and the **societal supports** we rely on.

### IV Findings

1. **Basic Needs and Security** - Low income → chronic stress, poor health, limited education → significantly lower life satisfaction.
2. **Relative Income and Social Comparison** - happiness depends on income relative to peers/friends.
3. **Spending Patterns** - Experiential Purchases (travel, events) boost happiness more than material purchases (gadgets)—they foster memories and social bonding.
4. **Financial Security vs. Wealth Accumulation** - Emergency Fund and debt-freedom contribute more to peace of mind than incremental wealth accumulation.

## **Practical Implications for Cultivating Happiness**

### **1. Meet Needs First**

Ensure basic living standards—then shift focus from earning more to experiencing more.

### **2. Mindful Spending**

Invest in relationships, personal growth, and giving rather than material accumulation.

### **3. Gratitude Practices**

Regularly acknowledge what you already have: reduces the urge for “more” and enhances life satisfaction.

### **4. Balance Work and Leisure**

Pursue meaningful activities and hobbies; avoid overwork simply to earn—it can erode well-being.

### **5. Community and Connectedness**

Use resources to foster social ties (family gatherings, community projects), which are strong predictors of happiness.

While money is essential to secure life’s necessities and can enhance happiness up to a point, true and lasting happiness depends more on **how** we use our resources—prioritizing relationships, experiences, purpose, and generosity over mere accumulation.

